

Californian yellow bush lupines are fast growing and invasive. The plant can upset the ecosystem by causing elevated nitrogen levels that attract nonnative species.

Extinction events

In extreme cases, a trophic cascade can lead to species extinction—as in the case of Steller's sea cows, marine mammals that once lived in the Bering Strait but were declared extinct in 1768. It has recently been argued that this extinction was caused by a calamitous trophic cascade, triggered by the hunting to virtual extinction of sea otters for the fur trade. The over-exploitation of sea otters allowed the population of sea urchins, their usual prey, to rise above a critical threshold. Sea urchins eat kelp, so the growth of their population led to a collapse in the extent of kelp forests—the sea cows' food source. Although the sea cows themselves were not being hunted, they soon became extinct. Understanding how such interventions,